How to Play: The Triangle Trade

The goal

Be the **first region** to get **everything** on your **secret needs list**.

New England	Middle Colonies	Southern Colonies	West Indies	England
Boston	Philadelphia	Charleston	Kingston	London

Your score = how much of your needs list you have. **Time's up and nobody finished?** The highest score wins. A tie goes to the team with **more voyages**.

The build-up: five steps

1 Read

Read your region's **Group Handout** on your own.

Rules for your region, the reading, and what you have. Readings come in four levels.

You'll use: Your Group Handout

2 Take notes

Fill in side 1 of the **Region Notes** sheet.

Products, needs, ships, who did the work, biggest advantage, biggest challenge.

You'll use: Region Notes, side 1

3 Plan as a team

Get your **Needs Card**. Copy your secret needs. Make a plan.

Your monopolies, your ship plan, your first move. Pick your Captain, Merchant and Harbormaster jobs.

You'll use: The Needs Card, Region Notes side 2, and the Harbormaster Record

4 Trade

Play **rounds**: Negotiation, then Shipping.

The teacher runs the clock and the Dock.

You'll use: Goods cards, the trade log, the Dock

5 Count up and reflect

Count your goods. Then think:

Why did England's trade laws make colonists angry, even though the laws helped some colonists?

You'll use: What we have, then the Reflection sheet

Your team's jobs

Captain (1 person)

- Carries out the deals in **Shipping**.
- Takes the goods cards to the **Dock**. Draws a **chance card** each way.
- Comes back to port **quickly**.

Merchant (1 person)

- The person **in charge of trade**.
- In **Negotiation**, visits another port to offer a deal.
- Say "yes if my team agrees." A deal counts only when your Harbormasters vote **yes**.
- No ship? Bargain at home with your Port Negotiator.

Harbormasters (everyone else)

- **Stay at your home port** the whole game.
- Keep the **record**. Talk with visiting Merchants.
- **Vote** on every deal. Each one also has a **Harbormaster job**.

Big rule: only the **Merchant** OR the **Captain** is away from port. **Never both.**

What's on your table

Table tent: your region's name and home port.

Goods cards: 28 cards in your region's color. **Ships are cards too.** Keep them in the bag.

Harbormaster Record, one per team. Side 1: **TOP SECRET** needs and a count of what you have. Side 2: the **trade log**.

Group Handout (your region's reading, rules and needs) and **Region Notes** sheet, one each.

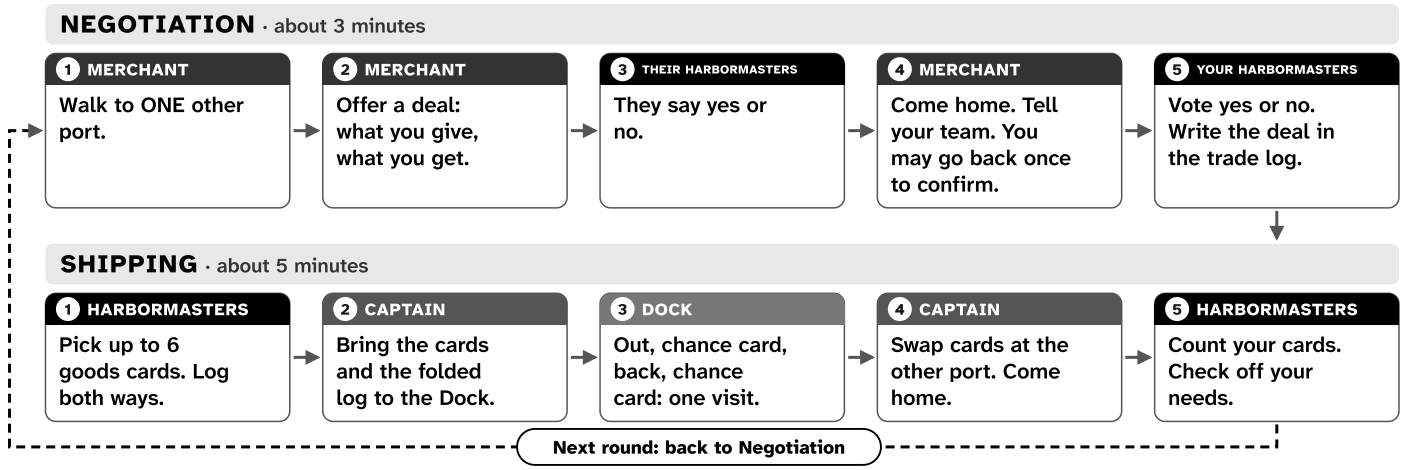
Harbormaster jobs

Every Harbormaster has one. Fewer than four Harbormasters? **Double up.**

- **Record Keeper** Writes every deal and voyage in the **trade log** before the Captain leaves.
- **Counter** Counts the goods cards at the end of each round, fills in **"What we have"** and checks off needs.
- **Port Negotiator** Meets visiting Merchants at your table and says what your team would **accept**.
- **Strategist** Watches the board and your needs list. Decides the Merchant's **next target**.

A round, step by step

A round is **Negotiation**, then **Shipping**. Rounds repeat until the teacher calls time.



The game's Negotiation rule: "NEGOTIATION ROUND — Regions with a ship may send their merchant to one other port to propose a trade. Nothing changes hands yet — harbormasters must approve every deal."

Ships

- A ship carries **6 goods at most**, each way.
- **One voyage per team** each Shipping round.
- New England, the Middle Colonies and England own ships (New England **7**, Middle Colonies **2**, England **8**).
- **No ship? Hire one:** make a deal with a team that has ships. The **fee rides as cargo**: load the goods you pay with in the hold (they count toward the 6), and they go to the ship's owner. The ship goes back to them.
- A hired voyage is **your** one voyage: your Captain takes your log to the Dock. The owner can still sail its own voyage that round.
- Or **trade for a ship card**. Tell the teacher at the Dock, so the game moves the ship to you. It isn't cargo. From the next Negotiation, your Merchant can go out.
- A ship can sail out **empty** to pick goods up, or come home empty after a delivery.

Chance cards

Two per voyage: one on the way out, one on the way home. The deck has **36** cards.

Good news — 21 of 36

×18 **Favorable Winds** Nothing happens. Sail on.

×1 **Free Passage!** Keep it. Later it cancels one card that costs you goods. Not the Admiralty Court.

×1 **Lucky Winds!** Add 1 good from home to the ship.

×1 **Governor's Favor** Choose any port to visit next.

Lose cargo — 9 of 36

Lose 1: Storm at Sea, **Sprung a Leak**

Lose 2: Pirates Spotted!, **Bad Weather**, **Rough Seas**, **Ship Needs Repairs**

Lose 3: Severe Storm!, **Pirates Board Your Ship!**, **Fire Below Deck!**

The Captain picks which goods.

Pay a duty — 2 of 36

×1 **Customs Inspection** Pay 1 good. They go to England.

×1 **British Tax Collector** Pay 2 goods. They go to England.

Admiralty Court — 4 of 36

×4 **Admiralty Court!** The court checks your trade log. Any mistake: England takes the **whole cargo**. Free Passage can't stop it.

Questions and answers

What if we don't have a ship?
Hire one or trade for one (see Ships). In Negotiation, only teams with a ship may send their Merchant out, so other Merchants will come to you.

Do we have to follow the triangle?
No. A ship can sail between **any two ports**.

Can we trade with England directly?
Yes. England is a port like the others.

Can we trade for something we don't need?
Yes. Sometimes you get a good so you can **trade it again** for something you do need.

Can the Merchant and the Captain both leave?
No. Only one of them is away from port at a time.

What if we lose goods on a chance card?
The Captain picks which goods from the ship. A **Free Passage** card can cancel it. Chance cards never take a ship.

What if the other team won't hand over the goods?
The deal was voted on in Negotiation, so it stands. The Dock's record is what happened. The teacher decides any argument.

What if the Dock's count and ours are different?
The **Dock's count is the official one**. Tell the teacher if you think it is wrong.

Why write every trade in the log?
The **Admiralty Court** can check it. A mistake means England takes the whole cargo.

What happens with rum in New England?
"Rum rule: each 1 rum traded uses up 2 molasses." That goes for any rum that leaves Boston, on any ship. The Dock takes the molasses and won't load more rum than your molasses allows, so trade for molasses first.

Who wins if nobody finishes?
The team with the most of its needs list. A tie goes to the team with more voyages.

Why did the teacher stop the game?
Sometimes the teacher **pauses the game** to ask the whole class a question. That's part of the game. Each trading day also ends with a few minutes on the **standings**.

Can we tell other teams what we need?
You can, but be careful. Your needs list is **TOP SECRET**. If others know what you need most, they can ask for more.

The history behind the game

This game scores **goods**. The real Triangle Trade also traded **people**.

On the second leg of the trade, ships carried **enslaved African people** across the Atlantic Ocean by force. That crossing is called the **Middle Passage**. Many people died on the way.

The sugar, tobacco, rice and indigo in this game were grown by **enslaved people**. They were forced to work and were **never paid**.

We'll hold the game and the history together in the debrief.

Teacher notes

Pause points

- **After Round 2 on the first trading day:** press **B** (Curtain) on the Dock to cover the board, then a 2–3 minute whole-class check:
  - Which good is everyone chasing?
  - Why can't every region finish?
  - Who holds the power, and where does it come from?
- **End of each trading day:** about 5 minutes on the standings.

Likely misunderstandings, and what to say

"England always wins." / "This is unfair."
That's the point. Ask why the system favored England: a monopoly on manufactured goods, the most ships (8), and duties paid to it.

"No one will trade with us." (usually the Middle Colonies)
True to history: food and lumber were plentiful. Ask what they could carry or broker instead.

"We traded a lot, so we did well."
Trading isn't winning. The score is the share of needs secured.

"The game was fun, so the trade was good."
That's the debrief's job: the scoring left out who did the work, and the people carried on the second leg.

Debrief plan

- Open the **debrief circle** in the last ~10 minutes of the second trading day, while the results are fresh. Start from the map: during play it draws only the voyages the class sailed (plus the Middle Passage, which no one sails). After End Game, 🗺 **Compare with the historical routes** lays the real triangles over them. *Did our trades make a triangle? Where did the wealth go, and whose labor produced it?*
- The next day (short, early release) is the written **CER**: *Why did England's trade laws make colonists angry, even though the laws helped some colonists?*

Running the Dock

- **One visit per voyage.** The Dock holds one voyage at a time, so run the whole thing while the Captain is there: cargo out from the log, first card, cargo back from the log's "Coming in", second card. The Captain then swaps cards at the other port, leaving behind whatever the cards took. About 45–60 seconds each.
- **One voyage per team per Shipping round** keeps the line to five, and keeps the teams with the most ships from also getting the most turns.
- The return cargo was agreed in Negotiation. If the other port no longer holds it, the Dock won't offer it; load what's there or sail home empty. A one-way delivery (a fee, a sale) is just a voyage with nothing loaded back.

- **The rum rule is automatic.** Whenever rum leaves Boston, on New England's ship or loaded there onto another team's ship for the trip back, the Dock takes 2 molasses per rum and won't load more rum than the molasses allows. Collect those molasses cards from New England then. A storm doesn't give them back.

Rules the Dock doesn't enforce

- Payment for a hired ship: **the fee rides as cargo**. Load the fee goods in the hold with the rest (they count toward the limit). If the voyage sails *to* the ship's owner, the Dock delivers the fee with everything else. If it sails somewhere else, leave the fee out of the Dock's cargo: the Captain hands those cards to the owner's port at the end of the voyage, and you move them with Log » Adjust Goods.
- A traded ship card moves only when you use Log » Transfer Ship.